

Trade in Preserved Foods and Spices



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Another way in which foods spread to new territories was along trade routes that transmitted nonperishable dry or preserved foods into areas where they were in demand but could not be grown, due to inhospitable climatic conditions or lack of appropriate agricultural knowledge. History is filled with such examples: the sugar trade from the Caribbean to Europe in the 18th to 20th centuries; the tea trade from China and India to Europe, beginning in the 18th century, and the spice trade from South and Southeast Asia to the Mediterranean and Europe, which began even before the Roman period. The Romans, however, did more to establish long-distance trade in food products than other earlier societies of the Mediterranean world. Not only did the Romans establish well-used trade routes on a new system of roads that stretched through their empire, from present-day Morocco to Iraq and Egypt to England, but they transported bulk goods throughout these territories for both Roman soldiers and local, non-Roman communities.



The Roman Empire at its maximum extent in 117 CE; both pink and green areas, though governed slightly differently, were core territories of the Empire.

Source: [Wikimedia Commons](#)

(https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:RomanEmpire_117.svg)

Wine is a key example of a commodity traded from this area into areas where it had been unknown, or rare and expensive (and unappreciated), before the Romans' arrival. The Vix krater, a massive (more than five feet in height!) bronze mixing bowl for wine manufactured in Greece, was

massive (more than five feet in height) bronze mixing bowl for wine manufactured in Greece, was brought to what is today central France and buried with a woman of high status. This vessel was not used for wine, but instead as an item of wealth displayed in the burial ritual and placed in the woman's grave. This vessel is a good example in which the paraphernalia of wine consumption, which was central to Greek culture, was used in a different culture as an item of social significance, detached from its original use—drinking wine—which was unknown in central France at the time.



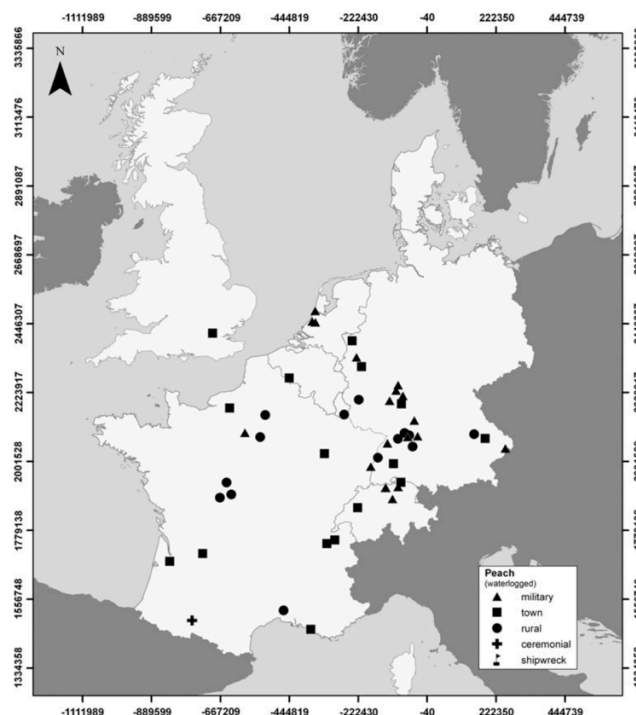
The Vix krater and a detail of the detailed Greek imagery on the neck and handles.

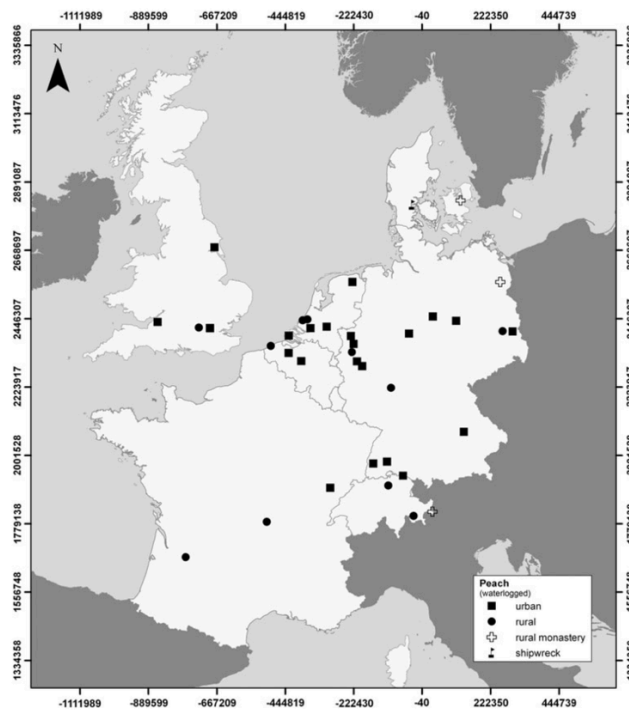
Source: [Wikimedia Commons](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chatil)

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[lon-sur-Seine_-](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chatil)
[Mus%C3%A9e du Pays chatillonnais_-](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Chatil)

[Crat%C3%A8re de Vix - 012.jpg](#); [Wikimedia Commons](#)
(https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/File:Chatillon-sur-Seine_-_Mus%C3%A9e_du_Pays_chatillonnais_-_Crat%C3%A8re_de_Vix_-_04.jpg)

This changed under Roman control of France, when the transport of wine, and then the cultivation of grapes and local production of wine, spread throughout the territory. The same occurred in what is now Spain, Portugal, and southern Germany, leading to a lasting legacy of wine production and consumption that long outlived the Roman Empire itself and continues into the present day. Wine was not the only commodity that spread across Europe during Roman rule: Dried dates, melon, cucumber, apricots, and peaches were transported as far as northern England. Where these crops could be grown locally, they were, with peaches, cucumber, and melons remaining established parts of local agricultural traditions well after the fall of the Roman Empire, as documented by [Alexandra Livarda in 2011](#) (<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s00334-010-0273-z>) through a survey of published paleoethnobotanical reports across western and northern Europe.





Roman (top) and medieval (bottom)
paleoethnobotanical finds of peach pits.

Source: Livarda, A. Spicing up life in northwestern Europe: Exotic food plant imports in the Roman and medieval world. *Veget Hist Archaeobot* 20, 143–164 (2011). <https://doi.org/10.1007/s00334-010-0273-z> (<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s00334-010-0273-z>)

Livarda also documented a robust trade in spices throughout the Roman Empire, including imported spices from Asia (especially black pepper), as well as those native to the Mediterranean region and not previously grown or used in northern Europe: caraway, celery, coriander, cumin, dill, fennel, nigella, parsley, savory, and sesame. Many of these became established parts of culinary traditions across Europe and as much a part of local cuisine as previously available herbs and spices.